

ITALIA ED EUROPA NELLA LINGUISTICA DEL RINASCIMENTO

*Italy and Europe
in Renaissance Linguistics*

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A CURA DI MIRKO TAVONI



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THE PLACE OF THE
DISSERTATIO DE STYLO PHILOSOPHICO NIZOLII
IN THE LEIBNIZIAN PRAISE OF THE GERMAN LANGUAGE

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At the suggestion of Boineburg, Leibniz in 1670 published a second edition of the work published in Parma in 1553 by the humanist Marius Nizolius (1488-1567), *De veris principiis et vera ratione philosophandi contra pseudo-philosophos*. Besides being accompanied with several observations, critical notes and bibliographical references, the text of Nizolius is preceded by a famous preface from Leibniz entitled *Marii Nizolii de veris principiis et vera ratione philosophandi contra pseudophilosophos*¹.

There are of course many interesting subjects both in Nizolius's text and in Leibniz's preface². But the main topic is, in both cases, the discussion of the stylistic features which should characterise philosophical discourse, a reason why this preface is usually known as the *Dissertatio de stylo philosophico Nizolii*. We will follow the discussion of this topic and its three main movements.

First movement: rhetoric versus natural language

Nizolius's *De veris principiis* is clearly a polemical work. It is the work of a humanist who adopts a very critical position in regard to the philosophy of the schools³, a text of a nominalist who contests the many artful medieval forms of

¹ In the following references I have used the abbreviations: Nizolius, *De veris principiis* = Marius Nizolius, *De veris principiis et vera ratione philosophandi contra pseudo-philosophos* [1553], a cura di Quirinus Breen, Roma: Fratelli Bocca Editori, 1956 (Edizione Nazionale dei Classici del Pensiero Italiano); Leibniz, *Dissertatio* = Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz, *Marii Nizolii de veris principiis et vera ratione philosophandi contra pseudophilosophos*, in *Die Philosophischen Schriften von Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz*, Hrsg. von Carl Immanuel Gerhardt (henceforth GP), vol. 4, Hildesheim: Olms, 1960, pp. 127-162. The text of Nizolius is even corrected by Leibniz according to the errata given in Nizolius's first edition and with regard to the writing of Greek words. Leibniz's preface has in fact become so important for the understanding of Nizolius' *De veris principiis* that the latter is usually published together with Leibniz's preface.

² Namely their position concerning Scholasticism, Nominalism, induction, logic, metaphysics, dialectics, rhetorics, etc.

³ He displays great and unusual admiration for Thomas Aquinas, however (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 346-347).

realism⁴, a writing of a logician who rejects the obscurities of metaphysicians, the frivolities of dialecticians, the inaccuracies of the Aristotelians. Aristotle himself is attacked and his Logic, mainly his theory of deduction, charged with being useless and formalist (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 314-315). But the *De veris principiis* is also a work aiming at an educational reform of higher instruction. This reform, according to Nizolius, must be undertaken on the basis of the recognition of the central and positive role of rhetoric, that oldest art of expression and true universal science which dictates the rules to which all other sciences, including philosophy, must obey in order to pursue and express their achievements (cfr. *De veris principiis* III 8).

For Nizolius, indeed, rhetoric must not be seen as a mere auxiliary of the philosophical discourse, a second moment, exterior, as it were, to its production, aiming solely to obtain the full attention of the reader or listener. On the contrary, rhetoric is a constitutive element of the philosophical work, the internal means of the very organisation of its concepts. The ways of investigating truth are coincident with the ways of expressing thought with clarity, of developing with elegance and order the subject matter, of exposing the several theses and arguments in a reasonable and persuasive manner. In other words, to be true, a discourse has to be eloquent; it must be clear, agreeable and persuasive; conversely, only a discourse with such properties can aspire to tell the truth (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 5-15). Moreover, only an eloquent philosophical discourse is able to show at work the search of the truth which characterizes philosophical activity and thus to promote the intelligent receptivity of the reader or the listener stimulating them in their own search for truth, that is to say, only in that way can philosophy be taught and learned (cfr. *De veris principiis*, p. 8). That is why for Nizolius philosophy can only be restored to its initial purity (that which prevailed before Socrates) if we follow the Ciceronian principle of the necessary alliance of rhetoric and philosophy, that is, if the union of wisdom and eloquence is re-established (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 210-212). It is precisely because these have been divorced, because it has been accepted, since the Gorgias of Plato, that dialectics should prevail above rhetoric as the most adequate method for the search for truth, that philosophy has declined in the obscurities of a «barbaric jargon» which, while giving the appearance of profundity, in fact conceals nothing but nebulosity and vacuity of thought. This barbaric jargon, characteristic of the «pseudo philosophers», is nothing but an empty, meaningless terminology unable to penetrate to the heart of things (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 11-12).

Leibniz, in his *Dissertatio*, agrees with Nizolius in the advantages of cultivating philosophy in a natural language. However, his defence of this thesis comes from a very different starting-point. As we have seen, Nizolius started out from a positive conception of rhetoric which he considers a necessary condition of the production

⁴ Nizolius praises the nominalism of Ockham whom he consequently already considers to be a modern (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 60 ff.).

of philosophical discourse. Once established, that philosophical discourse is entirely coincident with the art of its exposition; it follows that, those who care about truth must look for the art of using language with clarity and elegance (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 6-7). Philosophy requires then the ability to use a natural language, to explore the richness of its many ways of speaking, the immense variety of its terms and their potential of clarity, the capacity which only natural languages possess of revealing the very act of thinking in its movements and exigencies (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 7-8). For Leibniz, by contrast, rhetoric is not an internal component of philosophical discourse. Elegance is only important for capturing the attention of the listener or the reader and for facilitating memory. But the fundamental qualities of philosophical discourse are clarity and truth (cfr. *Dissertatio*, pp. 138-139). Now, because clarity is the necessary — yet not sufficient — condition of the truth, the important task for a philosopher is to look for the establishment of the conditions on which clarity depends and not to care about elegance, about the ways of capturing the attention of the listener and the reader (cfr. *Dissertatio*, pp. 138-139).

We recognise in this ideal of clarification a main topic and constant inspiration of Leibniz's philosophy; a topic which will also give rise to his many projects for construction of a universal philosophical language in which it is a question of achieving clarity by means of the construction of an artificial univocal symbolic system⁵. However, in the *Dissertatio*, the solution pointed out by Leibniz is quite different; it does not require the abandonment of natural language in favour of the construction of a new, entirely artificial symbolic system. On the contrary, the clarity needed for philosophical discourse comes from the uniformly respected definition of words, according to their origin and popular use (cfr. *Dissertatio*, pp. 140-141). Then, Leibniz's solution is here the exploitation of the cognitive potentialities of natural languages: the definition, as a process internal to language itself, of fixing and stabilising the meaning, and the use of a rich popular vocabulary. That is why he can conclude: «whatever cannot be explained in popular terms is nothing and should be exorcised from philosophy» (*Dissertatio*, p. 143).

We can thus conclude that both Leibniz and Nizolius emphasize the advantages of cultivating philosophy in natural language. But they set out from different starting-points and they follow different roads. For Nizolius it is praise of rhetoric that leads him to praise of the natural language as the necessary means of philosophical discourse; for Leibniz, if natural languages are especially suitable for philosophical work, this is because, through the grammatical processes they offer us (namely definition) and through the mediation of their vocabulary (namely popular usage and

⁵ As a matter of fact, such a project had by then already been sketched by Leibniz since, in the *Dissertatio de arte combinatoria* (1666) (GP 4, pp. 27-104), the construction of a universal language appears as one of the possible applications of the *ars combinatoria* (cfr. GP 4, pp. 72 ff.).

the antique origin of their commonplace terms) they open us an inexhaustible field of cognitive potentialities providing the guarantee of clarity which, above all, Leibniz wishes for. Also Nizolius wanted to get clarity. But he argued that clarity, being simultaneously a property of thought and a property of speech, can only be gained by the elegant use of an understandable language, that is to say, in Nizolius there is no opposition between elegance and clarity, between philosophy and rhetoric unlike in the case of Leibniz in this text.

It is yet to be discovered how such an opposition may be supported in a philosophical system like that one of Leibniz: a system in which the sign plays such a central, constitutive role and in which symbolism — significantly defined as blind thought («cogitatio caeca vel symbolica») — is said to be the vehicle and very element of thought⁶.

Second movement: natural language versus German language

If both Leibniz and Nizolius stressed the advantages of cultivating philosophy in the natural language, on this basis, Leibniz proceeds on to draw important conclusions regarding the excellence of German, something which obviously cannot be found in Nizolius.

For Nizolius the natural language required for the production and expression of philosophical discourse is any generally comprehensible language of ordinary people; a language which makes it possible to speak clearly and elegantly, choosing among a large variety of common ways of speaking, feeling and distinguishing their subtle differences of meaning; a language too in which there is no room for obscurities, verboisities and other empty abstract entities; in which it is impossible to formulate inconsistencies and incoherent questions simply because these cannot be expressed in a vulgar, healthy tongue, directly linked to reality by a direct correspondence of the words to the individual things. Hand in hand with his praise of the vernaculars, we also find in Nizolius praise of the classical languages of Homer and Cicero, the two languages in which, as he says, everything worthy to be known is written (cfr. *De veris principiis*, p. 6). This is not surprising since Nizolius was faced with the tension between the praise of the classical languages, the attempt to restore them to their initial purity (as a way to guarantee a faithful and devoted return to the texts of antiquity), and the commitment to the movement towards the development of national languages and literatures which emerged and enormously increased in the European Renaissance.

Now, as regards Leibniz, it can be said that he entirely transfers the praise of the philosophical qualities and potentialities of natural languages to German, which he

⁶On the constitutive function of symbolism in Leibniz's system, cfr. Pombo (1987, pp. 101-119).

considers the language best suited to philosophy. As he says: «No European language is better suited than German for this testing and examination of philosophical doctrines by a living tongue» (*Dissertatio*, p. 144). Three main reasons are given by Leibniz in the *Dissertatio* to explain that superiority: first, German is extremely rich in real terms, concrete terms which signify the concrete realities and the practical and mechanical activities of the people who have created and used them; second, German is poor at expressing fictions; third, German has a notorious incapacity to assimilate Latin and latinisms (cfr. *Dissertatio*, p. 144). The advantages of German as a philosophical language thus lie in certain characteristics of vocabulary which can mainly be reduced to a main one — the abundance of real, concrete terms, that is, words which maintain an immediate relation with empirical reality. Both the difficulty in expressing fictions and the incapacity to assimilate latinisms, derive from the «sense of the real» which makes German language impenetrable, so to speak, by fictions, abstractions devoid of content and the sterile verbosity of barbarous latinisms. It is here a question of gaining clarity, and thus access to the real, not through an attempt of formalisation (as with his projects for a universal language) but through respect for the popular terms and their concrete richness⁷.

In general, Leibniz was to maintain throughout his intellectual life the thesis of the superiority of the German language, which he first presented in the *Dissertatio* of 1670. Although this thesis is partially contradicted by Leibniz's own practice of writing⁸, it will be reaffirmed later⁹ and taken up again in future and much later texts¹⁰, mainly the

⁷ This richness of real or concrete terms is here attributed by Leibniz to the fact that, over the centuries, the German people had cultivated the practical and mechanical arts more than any other (cfr. *Dissertatio*, p. 144). It is important to note that, by praising the concreteness of the vocabulary of German language, Leibniz is not rejecting his ideal of the clarification of thought; on the contrary, being concrete, each term translates an immediate relation to the reality signified, thus avoiding the ambiguity and equivocalness that characterises abstract terms.

⁸ In fact, Leibniz wrote most of his principal works in Latin (as with the *Dissertatio* itself) and in French.

⁹ The defence of this thesis will even inspire certain measures of practical nature such as the proposal he made for the inclusion among the central objectives of the Berlin Academy of Sciences of the study of German language and of the obligatory writing in German of all works and reports of the future academy. See, for instance, *Consultatio de Naturae cognitione ad vitae usum promovenda, instituendaque in eam rem Societas Germana, quae scientias artesque maxime utiles vitae nostra lingua describat patriaeque honorem vindicet*, in: G. W. Leibniz, *Escritos de Filosofía Jurídica y Política*, Madrid: Editora Nacional, 1984, pp. 351-373.

¹⁰ Mostly as the consequence of the profound and most extensive etymological and philological investigations which Leibniz will later undertake.

*Nouveaux Essais sur l'entendement humain*¹¹ and the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken, betreffend die Ausübung und Verbesserung der Teutschen Sprache*¹².

In the *Nouveaux Essais*, after having established the common origin of all nations and the related existence of a primordial language, Leibniz stresses the superiority of German in view of its antiquity. As he says, of all existing tongues, «le Teuton a plus gardé du naturel et (pour parler le langage de Jacob Bohm) de l'Adamique» (*Nouveaux Essais*, GP 5, p. 260). The primordial character of German is reinforced in the *Nouveaux Essais* by the demonstration of its naturalness. As is well known, Leibniz stresses, by means of a series of examples, the onomatopoeic origin of many German words, the phonetic symbolism of its letters, the articulatory and expressive motivation of its names; features which are ultimately the traces of a naturalness which, in spite of all the transformations and losses, German more than any other language still retains (cfr. *Nouveau Essais*, GP 5, pp. 261-262). So if, in the *Dissertatio*, the superiority of German for philosophical purposes derives from the concreteness of its terminology, that is to say, is established by means of analysis of its current vocabulary, in the *Nouveaux Essais* he adopts a genetic, etymological approach: the reason for the superiority of German lies in its antiquity, in its primordial (Adamic) naturalness.

Let us now consider the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedanken*, where a slight but significant shift of emphasis can be detected. The purpose of this text is less to exalt or account for the virtues of German — although this element is also present — than to appeal for its improvement, to call for a collective effort to protect its virtues and correct its imperfections and defects. These imperfections consist mainly of the absence of an adequate terminology for the signification of all those realities which have no immediate relation to the sensory, for instance, to express feelings, values, moral and political concepts and other yet more abstract and sublime matters, as Leibniz says (cfr. *Unvorgreiffliche Gedanken*, § 10). What we wish to stress is that, if in the *Dissertatio*, Leibniz praised the German language for its richness in concrete terms and in the *Nouveaux Essais* he gave that concreteness an etymological basis, now, in the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedanken*, what he regrets is the lack of abstract terms.

Does this shift in emphasis indicate a contradiction in Leibniz's position? Is it an important and significant alteration of doctrine? In order to answer this question it is necessary to go back again to the *Dissertatio*, namely to the role attributed there to technical terms in philosophical discourse.

¹¹ GP 5, pp. 39-509. Henceforth: *Nouveaux Essais*.

¹² Gothofredi Guillelmi Leibnitii, *Opera Omnia, Nunc primum collectata, in classes distributa, praefationibus et indicibus exornata, studi Ludovico Dutens*, Genevae: Fratres de Tournes, 1768, tom. 6.2, pp. 6-51. We will use the abbreviated form *Unvorgreiffliche Gedanken*.

Third movement: technical terms versus barbarian obscurities

As we have seen, like Nizolius, Leibniz stressed in the *Dissertatio* the need to avoid the use of technical terms which, as he said, always suppose some obscurity. Technical terms should be eschewed wherever possible (cfr. *Dissertatio*, p. 141) since, as Leibniz stated then, «everything which cannot be expressed in the language of the people should be exorcised from philosophy» (*Dissertatio*, p. 143). However, already in the *Dissertatio*, his position was not so easy. Even then, he recognized the need and the legitimacy of the use of technical terms in some specific circumstances; they are condensed forms of meaning which economically substitute that which, in ordinary language, can only be said in a prolix form¹³. So they may be justifiably employed in mathematics, physics and mechanics, and they are needed to refer to «those realities to which no name has been given by the people» (*Dissertatio*, p. 142).

That is to say, what in fact, in the *Dissertatio*, Leibniz intended to stress by indicating the need to avoid, as far as possible, the use of technical terms, was solely the condemnation, following Nizolius, of the sterile, obscure and obscurantist verbosity which characterises barbarian philosophy. Now, the abstract vocabulary which, in the *Unvorgreifliche Gedanken*, Leibniz argues that German should try to acquire has nothing in common with the «empty words» and futile latinisms used by those pedantic masters of dialectics whom, like Nizolius, Leibniz had in mind. As already recognized by Leibniz in the *Dissertatio*, there are some circumstances in which philosophy requires the use of technical terms. As condensed forms of meaning which economically replace the prolix forms of ordinary language, they are an essential instrument of precision, accuracy and rigor; employed in mathematics or physics and in general to refer those realities to which no name has been assigned, their conceptual function is indispensable; they are necessary instruments of science and reflective thought. But Leibniz goes even a little further stressing that, when used with moderation, they are of vital importance seeing that only they are able to show the reader or listener the activity of modulation and conceptual creativity which characterises philosophical activity. This is what Leibniz recognises in a very interesting passage of the *Dissertatio* which deserves attention:

For philosophers are superior to common people not in what they think but rather in the fact that they think *in a different way*, that is, with the eye of the mind, with reflection and attention, and

¹³ That is what Leibniz exemplifies with the term «square» which, he shows, may be resolved into a series of terms like quadrilateral, equilateral, rectangular, side, angle, right, etc. (cfr. *Dissertatio*, p. 142). As Leibniz says: «even the blind can see how annoying it would be, and how awkward, to have always to use all these words in place of the word 'square' in our demonstrations» (*ibid.*).

comparing things with each other. And there is no better way to arose the attention of men for a certain matter than to assign it a definite name (*Dissertatio*, pp. 142-143; our emphasis).

In this passage, Leibniz fully recognizes that the work of creation of names (technical terms, therefore) is an integral part of philosophical activity. A new name is not only a new way of saying but also a new way of seeing and of drawing attention to it. In a word, to create a concept is not very far from the onomatopoeic activity of giving it a name. Leibniz further recognises the legitimacy of philosophical discourse in order to disclose in the receptor an effect of receptivity towards the philosophical activity, that is, he recognises that philosophical discourse demands a philosophical style. It must be constructed in such way as to be able to call attention to the activity which underlies it. This means that, like Nizolius, and if only for different reasons, Leibniz comes, after all, to recognize an internal, positive rhetoric in the production of philosophical discourse; that is to say, he has to agree with Nizolius in what, at the first sight, the *Dissertatio* seemed to deny.

However, while Nizolius stressed mainly the effect of clarity coming from the rhetoric potentialities of natural languages while utterly denying the need of naming abstract entities which his strict — and extensionally closed — nominalism does not allow him to accept¹⁴, Leibniz mostly regards that rhetoric level as the legitimation to create, in certain circumstances, new names to designate the conceptual abstract qualities which his keen — and logically opened — nominalism does not prevent him from recognising. This also means that, much more than Nizolius, Leibniz is aware of the language difficulties inherent to the constitution of a philosophical discourse. He knows that philosophy needs natural languages; he knows that only they, being endowed since their very creation by the anonymous people with a naturalness which makes of them the very seed of meaning, are able to adequately signify the world.

But he also knows that plain acceptance of a natural language is not enough for the exigencies of philosophical discourse. In view of the prolix, irregular nature of those living organisms which ordinary languages are, they always involve some obscurities, inaccuracies and ambiguities; endowed with a remarkable sense of the real, they do not spontaneously have names for the new abstract realities created by

¹⁴ In fact, the condemnation by Nizolius of the medieval obscurities of scholastic philosophy, his claim that technical terms must be not only avoided but entirely rejected, must be seen as a consequence of his strict rejection of the possibility of any substantive signification of abstract entities (cfr. *De veris principiis*, pp. 48-55). This strict nominalism is precisely analysed and strongly criticised by Leibniz in the *Dissertatio* where Leibniz argues that, on the contrary of what Nizolius wrongly stressed, universals do not have a collective but a distributive nature (cfr. *Dissertatio*, pp. 160-161).

science and reflective thought. That is why the philosopher, taking advantage of the rhetorical and heuristic possibility of working within ordinary languages, has also to accept his responsibilities at such a level, daring to change the rules, to modify established uses, to discover other senses in the richness of ordinary words; that is to say, to create new abstract, technical names in order to signify those realities which people have not thought out (or, named therefore) but which, he, through *his different way of thinking*, by means of *the new perspective* he is able to introduce, is in position to identify.

Now, precisely because those technical terms are not a spontaneous creation of the anonymous people, because they are deliberately created by the philosopher, that is, artificially instituted by him, they run the risk of not being endowed with the motivational qualities of the words of natural languages, that is, they risk being arbitrary (merely conventional) and thus *obscure*, not understandable by the common people. However, that is the price which the philosopher has to pay in order to be able to keep discovering new realities and bring them to the *light* of names. That is why in the *Unvorgreifliche Gedanken* Leibniz advises that the invention of new terms must obey the law of similarity as a way of recovering, as far as possible, the motivational laws which regulate natural languages (*Unvorgreifliche Gedanken*, § 75). That is also why, in the *Dissertatio*, when Leibniz is dealing with the status of the technical terms in philosophical discourse — they must be avoided but, at the same time, they can be used and even created in certain circumstances — we can say that he is already trying to reconcile the opposition inherent in the constitution of philosophical discourse.

In the case of Nizolius, it was, in some way, his strict nominalism that prevented him distinguishing, as Leibniz does, two different levels within the class of *technical terms*: *empty terms* which exemplify the sterile, obscure terminology of barbarous philosophy and which he, like Leibniz, wanted to denounce, and *abstract terms* which Nizolius entirely rejected and which Leibniz accepted with good judgement as indispensable instruments of science and reflective thought.

By distinguishing these two levels, Leibniz was able to gain a deeper understanding than Nizolius of the internal difficulties of philosophical discourse, namely the tension between *clarity* and *obscurity* which underlies it. When, later, in the *Unvorgreifliche Gedanken*, one of the last texts Leibniz wrote, we see him still advocating the improvement of a natural language, German, in order to make it a suitable vehicle for the demands of philosophical discourse and, knowing that, simultaneously and in parallel throughout his intellectual career, he tried hard to construct an artificial philosophical language, we realize that he set his sights too high: not only did he aim to reconcile the *light/shadow* aporias which are in tension within the constitution of a philosophical discourse, but similarly he aimed to reconcile meaning (which only natural languages can give us) and the rigor (which implies the meaningless formalism of a symbolic system).

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RIASSUNTO

Concentrando la nostra attenzione sulla *Dissertatio de stylo philosophico Nizolii*, la nota prefazione di Leibniz al *De veris principiis et vera ratione philosophandi contra pseudo-philosophos* di Marius Nizolius, cerchiamo dapprima di individuare gli argomenti di maggior rilievo presenti in entrambi gli autori relativi alle qualità richieste alla lingua nell'esprimere discorsi filosofici; quindi analizziamo le ragioni portate da Leibniz a fondamento della tesi, qui presente per la prima volta, della superiorità del tedesco come lingua filosofica; e, in terzo luogo, illustriamo il ruolo della *Dissertatio* nelle successive formulazioni di tale tesi. Riteniamo che questo testo, scritto in gioventù, sia di estrema importanza per comprendere la posizione di Leibniz circa la superiorità della lingua tedesca.

SUMMARY

By focusing our attention mainly on the *Dissertatio de stylo philosophico Nizolii*, the famous preface from Leibniz for Marius Nizolius's *De veris principiis et vera ratione philosophandi contra pseudo-philosophos*, we try, first, to identify the main arguments presented by both authors concerning the language qualities required for the expression of philosophical discourse; secondly, to discuss the reasons presented by Leibniz in order to substantiate the thesis, here presented for the first time, of the superiority of German as a philosophical language; and thirdly, to show the place of the *Dissertatio* within Leibniz's later formulations of such a thesis. We argue that this text written in his youth is of extreme importance for understanding Leibniz's position regarding the excellence of the German language.

Il convegno "Italia ed Europa nella linguistica del Rinascimento. Confronti e relazioni", che dal 20 al 24 marzo 1991 riunì, presso l'Istituto di Studi Rinascimentali di Ferrara, centocinquanta studiosi provenienti da tutti i paesi europei, dal Nordamerica e da altri continenti, era nato da un'idea comparativa e interdisciplinare della storia delle idee linguistiche in Europa dal XIV al XVII secolo. Era nato dall'idea che nell'Europa dell'Umanesimo e del Rinascimento la circolazione sovranazionale delle idee linguistiche fosse più intensa di quanto le nostre abitudini di ricerca, fortemente incanalate per distinte storie linguistiche nazionali, siano mediamente capaci di render conto; e dall'idea che la storia della riflessione sul linguaggio e sulle lingue in un'epoca 'pre-paradigmatica' come il Rinascimento potesse risultare tanto più fruttuosa quanto più riuscisse a far interagire gli approcci di specialisti diversi: storici delle varie lingue e delle varie letterature, filologi umanisti, linguisti generali, storici della filosofia, storici della scrittura e della tipografia, storici *tout court*, ecc. Agiva anche l'idea del ruolo propulsivo dell'Italia nel diffondere in Europa, nel corso del Quattrocento, la rinnovata grammatica latina umanistica, e nel fornire poi, per tutto il Cinquecento, il modello per le "questioni della lingua" che nei vari paesi accompagnano con coloriture diverse l'affermazione delle moderne lingue nazionali. Ma agiva anche la consapevolezza che, in parallelo con il declino politico dell'Italia, una sua relativa marginalizzazione dalle correnti più innovative del pensiero linguistico si rilevava già fin dalla metà del Cinquecento rispetto alle nuove grammatiche razionalistiche concepite in Francia e in Spagna e alla "linguistica missionaria" e di conquista che stava spostando fuori dal Mediterraneo il baricentro anche della riflessione sulle lingue. Da tutto ciò il progetto di promuovere un ampio confronto interdisciplinare fra le varie tradizioni linguistiche, volto sia alla ricerca dei contatti storici fra di esse, sia al confronto tipologico capace di illuminare contrastivamente ognuna di esse in confronto alle altre.

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